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Revolt, the modern state, and colonized subjects, 1848–1885

The revolt of 1857–8, which swept across much of north India in opposition to British rule, has conventionally been taken as the dividing point that marks the beginning of modern India. Historical periodization is, however, always somewhat arbitrary. With greater distance from the colonial period, when the searing chaos of the uprising was understood either as ‘Mutiny’ to the colonial rulers or as the ‘First War of Independence’ to many nationalists, it is possible to focus on substantial, long-term transformations rather than on a single event. Such an emphasis, moreover, places India in the context of changes taking place in the larger world, not just in terms of events and personalities in India itself. Far from modernity ‘happening’ in Europe and then being transplanted to a country like India, many of these changes took place in relation to each other.

Modern technological changes, among them canals, railways, and telegraph, were introduced into India within years of their introduction in Europe. Changes essential to the modern state, including the unification of sovereignty, the surveying and policing of the population, and institutions meant to create an educated citizenry were also, broadly speaking, introduced during the same period in India and in parts of Europe. Indeed, certain modern practices and institutions were either stimulated by the Indian experience or originated in India itself. Municipal cemeteries, as noted above, appeared in India before they did in England; the same is true of English literature as a curricular subject, and of state-sponsored scientific and surveying institutions. The colonial relationship with India was essential,

moreover, as Gauri Vishwanathan recently argued, to one of the fundamental characteristics of modern states, namely the practice of state secularism. At the same time, new religious organizations in both India and Britain shared the common pattern of an unprecedented involvement of the laity. In both countries too, the spread of electoral politics was accompanied by debate over the place of religion in public life. Above all, the economic lives of both countries were profoundly, and increasingly, intertwined.

The date 1848 as starting point for the ‘modern state’ in India is a reminder, however, of a key difference in the nature of the state in India. In Europe during 1848 a wave of protests swept across the continent demanding expansion of the suffrage and other political reforms. In Britain, the Chartist movement, gaining support from economic depression and the limited expansion of suffrage brought about by the Reform Act of 1832, brought the working classes on to the streets in an effort to secure political power for themselves. The opportunities for a public voice and public life varied greatly among regions in India, but even in Bengal, where modern voluntary associations and publications were most widespread, relatively few voices could be raised to demand such political reforms before the end of the century. In politics, as in economic life, an authoritarian colonial state constrained Indian aspirations.

Most historians now agree that the rigidities introduced by colonial policy decisively shaped, even distorted, modernity in India. This approach offers a corrective to what was too easily described during the colonial era as the ‘blessings of British rule’, namely the pacification and unification of the country, legal codification, the use of the English language, public works, and a range of social reforms. Critics of European modernity, among them Britons as well as Indians, even at the time saw the dark side of these changes, among them racism, militarism, and the economic exploitation that was part of the colonial relationship. What coloured those ‘blessings’ above all was a mentality that discounted Indian abilities and aspirations to self-rule, an attitude the historian Francis Hutchins termed the British ‘illusion of permanence’. British rule in the 1830s and 1840s had been founded in Enlightenment notions of universal human destiny and expectations of progress, although, to be sure, even then an authoritarian strain was evident in evangelical and

utilitarian reform. But by the 1870s the mood was different, above all in an explicitly authoritarian attitude among colonial officials. They were, for the most part, convinced of an essential difference between British and Indian that justified indefinite control of political power by a 'superior race'.

DALHOUSIE: THE UNIFICATION OF SOVEREIGNTY AND NETWORKS OF COMMUNICATION

At the end of the nineteenth century, John Beames recalled his early days as a wet-behind-the-ears civil servant in the late 1850s:

But Adams [his superior] had told me as we walked along that the work was so heavy he could hardly get through it, so I suppose he had no time for teaching beginners. My stock of available knowledge consisted of Persian and Hindustani . . . Of law and procedure I, of course, knew nothing . . . I said as if by instinct, 'Call up the first case' . . . Both these people spoke Panjabi, of which I could not understand one word, but the sarishtadar [chief clerk] translated it into Hindustani as they spoke, so I got on wonderfully well . . . I next began to learn Panjabi, for which purpose I engaged an old Sikh priest . . . Like most Panjabis of those days the good Bhai was a kindly, simple-hearted old child . . . They are a fine, manly race . . . There was no law in the Panjab in those days. Our instructions were to decide all cases by the light of common sense and our own sense of what was just and right . . .

[Elmslie, his Haileybury classmate and now colleague] and I were in the saddle by five in the morning and worked on horseback for two or three hours, riding about inspecting police-stations, roads and bridges and public building under construction, tree-planting, ferry-boats, settling disputes about land and property between villagers, and such like business. Or we would walk with our horses led behind us through the narrow lanes of the ancient town, accompanied by a crowd of police officers, overseers, and others giving orders for sanitary improvements, repairing roadways and drains, opening out new streets, deciding disputes and a variety of similar matters . . . Hard work as usual filled up the day.

Beames's recollections illustrate pervasive attitudes that shaped British rule in India from mid-century. A paternalist self-assurance, with a commitment to material progress and hard work, were as true of James Ramsey, Marquis of Dalhousie, who served as governor-general from 1848 to 1856, as they were of the young John Beames in the Punjab countryside. Dalhousie arrived in Calcutta with a two-pronged vision that set in place significant elements of the

framework of what turned out to be the remaining century of British rule. Dalhousie was committed, in the first place, to unifying British sovereignty both territorially and legally. And he was convinced of the importance of new networks for communications and transportation in India as well.

Dalhousie's arrival coincided with the Second Sikh War in 1848–9, which brought about the annexation of the rich, strategically critical, province of Punjab, and so extended the Raj up to the Khyber Pass. Dalhousie also reluctantly, but effectively, prosecuted a military campaign in Burma in 1852, responding primarily to commercial interests, and annexed lower Burma (as a prelude to Dufferin's final annexation of the whole country in 1886). Under Dalhousie's direction, the administration of the Punjab was entrusted to a coterie of like-minded officers under the strong direction of two brothers, John and Henry Lawrence. In the tension between rule through codification and system on the one hand, and enlightened despotism on the other, the 'Punjab School' tilted to the latter. Driven by confidence in the 'man on the spot' and a belief that they alone could bring order and prosperity to a contented peasant society, Punjab officials enjoyed a wider range of discretionary authority than was true elsewhere. The power entrusted to Beames, at age twenty-three with no experience, is telling. The Jallianwalla Bagh massacre of 1919, evidence of the tragic side of such official power, is telling as well.

A second dimension of the push to unification was an effort to curtail princely sovereignty. The modern state could not tolerate, from Dalhousie's perspective, the nested sovereignties and fluid boundaries characteristic of earlier regimes. At the very beginning of his administration, Dalhousie wrote, 'I cannot conceive it possible for any one to dispute the policy of taking advantage of every just opportunity which presents itself for consolidating the territories which already belong to us, by taking possession of States that may lapse in the midst of them.' In so doing Dalhousie hoped to gain, he continued, security, financial resources, and the promotion of the 'best interests' of those thus ruled. By 'lapse' Dalhousie meant the death of a ruler without a natural heir in any state created by or dependent on the British. He thus chose not to recognize the widespread custom of adoption to secure an heir. By this device, Dalhousie secured

possession of seven states in seven years, in central India, Bengal, Rajasthan, and the Punjab hills. Among them were Satara and Nagpur, both significant Maratha states, and Jhansi, whose woman ruler would soon take to battle. Dalhousie also used the justification of 'lapse' to terminate pensioners' subsidies, among them that of Nana Sahib, the adopted son of the Maratha peshwa of Poona. Dalhousie's final annexation was that of Awadh (known under the British as Oudh) in 1856, richest state of all, not by the 'doctrine of lapse' but on the grounds of persistent misgovernment. He even sought (checked by demurrals at home) an end to the titular rule of the Mughal at Delhi, as whose servant, legally, the Company continued to operate. Whatever 'feudal' façades were to be created in the aftermath of 1857, the British were to insist upon the principle of unified sovereignty, including a monopoly of military force, held firmly in British hands.

The second prong of Dalhousie's vision was his embrace of the new technologies that were transforming the West. They were to prove essential to the cultural, political, and economic integration that would emerge both within India and between the colony and the metropole. The railway, the telegraph, the postal service, and improved steam transport together transformed the imperial system of the late nineteenth century. The potential of the railway for India was clear to Dalhousie, who had worked with Gladstone at the Board of Trade in London during the railway fever of the 1840s. He was convinced that the railway would be the key to the spread of British power and civilization. Above all, it would extend the market for British manufactured goods, and secure access to raw materials such as cotton needed by British industry. The railway would also serve military interests. As Dalhousie wrote to the Court of Directors in 1853, it would allow the concentration of military strength as needed 'in as many days as it would now require months to effect'. Dalhousie oversaw the beginning of railway construction, starting with two lines from Howrah (Calcutta) and Bombay. To reach his first posting, in 1859 Beames rode the train from Howrah to the end of the line, only a little over 100 miles at that point; most of the rest of the way he perched on top of his luggage on a horse cart, taking some twenty-four days in all to reach the Punjab. By the end of the century this was a journey of under three days by train.

The building of the railway offers a window into the working of the British Raj in India at mid-century. The project was funded by British capital, raised for multiple companies who operated in different locations. The Company, and after 1858 the Crown, guaranteed the investors, virtually all British, a 5 per cent (or in some cases 4.5 per cent) return, absolutely risk free. This was the first transfer of British capital to India, for the Company, and earlier private investors, had financed their activities through funds raised in India itself. The railway profits, which could have financed India's own development, went instead into the pockets of investors in Britain. The building of the railways, furthermore, provided a market for British goods. Rails, locomotives, rolling stock, and other manufactured goods and even, at times, British coal and Baltic firs creosoted in England, were exported to India. This meant that a major public works project that might have served as a 'leading sector' to generate 'multiplier effects' for India's industrialization had no such effect. The layout of the track supported the extractive and market focus of British economic interests, linking the hinterland to the colonial port cities and those cities to each other. The 'classic' shape of a colonial economy, with market crops like cotton, jute, and tea exported in return for cloth and other manufactured goods, was only possible because of the railway.

The railway was, on the whole, well built at reasonable cost. One limit to its effectiveness came from the disjunctures resulting from track of differing width, with both metre gauge, built as a cost-saving device to accommodate lighter use, and broad gauge. But the cost of moving goods fell dramatically; the value of the railway in providing famine relief was critical; and countless individual Indians enthusiastically took to train travel, for example to visit family members and pilgrimage sites, all results only barely imagined when the first track was laid.

Although limited in its impact to specific areas, Dalhousie energetically encouraged extension of irrigation canal systems. His years in office saw the completion of approximately 500 miles of the Ganges Canal, a source of irrigation water for a vast hinterland, with all the disruptions, both positive and negative, that such a resource brought. In the long term, the most obvious negative consequence was to be salinization of vast areas as the excess water drew salt on

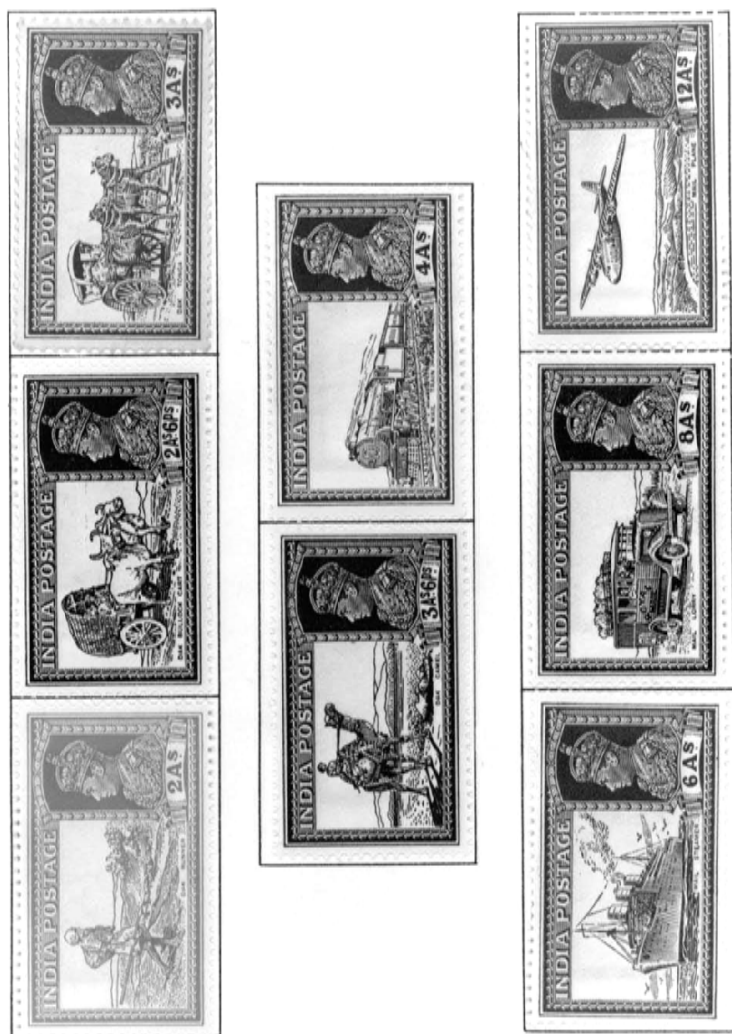


Plate 4.1 A set of Government of India postage stamps, 1937, with scenes of delivering the mail. The four lower value stamps, labelled 'dak', show human and animal carriers, while the higher values depict mechanized 'mail' transport.

to the surface of the irrigated land. The telegraph linking the chief centres of India was completed during Dalhousie's term. Comprising some 4,500 miles of line, it made possible rapid transmission of information on politics, security, trade, and industry, as well as the personal messages of ever more individuals. The cable linking Britain and India (its development spurred by the revolt of 1857) was laid in 1865, a year before the link between Britain and the US. Indeed, the first attempt at an underwater cable at all was probably one stretched across the Hooghly in Calcutta in 1839.

In 1854, moreover, a government postal service was established, bringing to India the same 'penny post' introduced in Britain some fifteen years earlier. Mail could now be sent, the cost to the sender, any distance within the country, at the same low cost. This facility served not only individuals, including people in remote villages (who often depended on literate letter writers and readers clustered outside office buildings), but was indispensable to the communications and fundraising of the voluntary societies, organizations, and publishers emerging in this period. Some indication of the variety of mail delivery services utilized even in twentieth-century India can be seen in the set of stamps shown in [plate 4.1](#), issued on the occasion of the coronation of the King-Emperor George VI. The mid-century years also saw significant improvements in steamship design with the faster, safer iron hull and the high-pressure engine. Although there is no clear turning point in the introduction of these innovations, one landmark date was in fact 1848, when the Peninsular and Oriental bought the first iron steamers for their Indian Ocean routes. In the 1830s an exchange of letters between Britain and India could take two years; by 1870, with the opening of the Suez Canal, a letter could reach Bombay in only one month.

Dalhousie thus set in place the legal underpinnings of a unified state, with defined boundaries, and individual subjects on whom that state would impinge. He had substantially advanced, moreover, the technological infrastructure that would transform the everyday experience of both state and subjects in myriad ways. The revolt of 1857 seemed to call the very presence of the British into question. What it did not do was reverse these changes.

1857, CROWN RULE, AND THE AFTERMATH OF REVOLT

Throughout 1857, and into 1858, northern India was caught up in a rebellion that shook the Raj to its foundations. As the unrest subsided, an Indian official serving the Raj, Sayyid Ahmad Khan (1817–98), sought its causes:

I believe that there was but one primary cause of the rebellion, the others being merely incidental and arising out of it. Nor is this opinion either imaginary or conjectural. It is borne out by the views entertained by wise men of past ages: and all writers on the principles of Government agree in it... It has been universally allowed that the admittance of the people to a share in the Government under which they live, is necessary to its efficiency, prosperity, and permanence. [Moreover,] [t]he Natives of India, without perhaps a single exception, blame the Government for having deprived them of their position and dignity and for keeping them *down*... What! Have not [the British ICS officers'] pride and arrogance led them to consider the Natives of India as undeserving the name of human beings... What! Was not the Government aware that Natives of the very highest rank trembled before its officers, and were in daily fear of suffering the greatest insults and indignities at their hands?

Raised in a family close to the Mughal court, by 1857 Sayyid Ahmad had spent twenty years in Company service. He was conspicuously loyal during the uprising, evacuating the European residents from the town of Bijnor, where he was serving, and even taking charge of the district on behalf of the British for some time. His essay, written in Urdu and subsequently translated into English, evoked great interest on the part of the British. He correctly insisted, contrary to British wishful thinking at the time and after, that the Revolt was not merely a mutiny on the part of disgruntled soldiers. It was, rather, he argued, a response to multiple grievances. Among these were British cultural policies, the severity of revenue assessments, and the degradation of landed and princely elites, notably the recently exiled nawab of Oudh. Above all, Sayyid Ahmad faulted the insolence and contempt for Indians evinced by the British, and insisted on the importance of a consultative process that would include them. If it was this key issue of British and Indian relations that precipitated the revolt, it was, ironically, to be in the very intensification of racial distance that the uprising would find its most enduring legacy.

The revolt began with a military mutiny, borne of festering grievances among the soldiers of the Bengal Army. There had been discontent at assignments to Burma, resulting in the 1856 General Services Enlistment Act requiring sepoys to serve wherever posted. There was dissatisfaction with pay and the limited opportunities for promotion. The annexation of Oudh unsettled the high-caste sepoys from that province, who formed one-third of the Bengal Army. And, as the proximate cause, there was the new Lee Enfield rifle, whose use required soldiers to bite off the end of each cartridge – widely reputed to have been greased with pig or cow fat, polluting to both Hindus and Muslims. When sepoys refused to load the rifles, they were publicly humiliated, even expelled from service. On 10 May 1857, in the hot Indian summer, the sepoys posted to Meerut in north India, who had seen eighty-five of their colleagues led off in chains the previous day, rose up in the night, massacred the English residents of the town, and marched on Delhi. There they sought to raise anew the standard of the Mughals under the aged emperor Bahadur Shah, whose name ('the valiant') belied his real achievement – as a poet. As sepoys elsewhere flocked to the rebel cause, the British lost control over a broad swathe of north India, from Bihar to Punjab, as well as pockets of central India. In some areas it took them a year to fight their way back.

Within weeks, taking advantage of the space opened up by the dispossession of the British, disaffected groups in the countryside, landlords and peasants, princes and merchants, each, for their own reasons, took up arms. There was never any coherent strategy for ousting the British from India. The Mughal emperor, the Queen-Regent of Oudh, the Maratha chief Nana Sahib, and others claimed leadership of the uprising. To be sure, a religious rhetoric was often adduced to justify opposition to what was seen as a corrupt moral order, but there was no unifying ideology of any kind. Some rebels, indeed, sought no more than their own immediate advantage, and so settled down, like Devi Singh, the 'King of Fourteen Villages' in Mathura, to plunder the wealthy and prosecute quarrels with their neighbours. 'Loyalty' and 'rebellion' were always fluid concepts. The participation of one magnate in the uprising often encouraged his rivals to throw in their lot with the British in hopes of gaining an advantage should the tide of war turn.

It is important to differentiate between events in the recently annexed province of Oudh and those in the older, more settled districts. The revolt in Oudh, as Rudrangshu Mukherjee has forcibly argued, took on the shape of a 'popular' movement, with all classes fighting on behalf of their sepoy kinsmen and deposed king Wajid Ali Shah. Most prominent among the revolt's supporters were the taluqdari landlords, aggrieved by the loss of villages during the 1856 land settlement, who, from the security of their mud forts, rallied their followers, kinsmen, and tenants. Although many among the peasantry had won title to their lands in 1856, to the dismay of the British they threw in their lot with their former landlords – to have boldly confronted them would have been foolhardy – and together they marched on Lucknow to join the siege of the tiny British garrison there.

The revolt in the adjacent North-Western Provinces was of a different sort. There, the response to the uprising was shaped by the experience of fifty years of British rule. As the historian Eric Stokes demonstrated in a series of careful local studies, those rural magnates who had profited from the commercial opportunities brought by the British tended to be loyal, even smothering the sparks of unrest among their tenantry, while those who had lost wealth and consequence often took advantage of the engulfing anarchy to join the revolt. Where tightly knit cultivating communities, especially Jat and Rajput brotherhoods, held the land, they often rose without magnate leadership to protest the heavy differential revenue assessments laid upon them. The revolt in the North-Western Provinces can thus usefully be described as a 'post-pacification' revolt, where long festering but diffuse grievances erupted, by contrast with the 'primary resistance' of the Oudh revolt, where a recently deposed royal family provided leadership. In this way it is possible to link 1857 to uprisings elsewhere that took place in the early stages of colonialism, and to distinguish it from the modern, nationalist protests that followed.

Many remained loyal throughout, and in so doing secured the ultimate defeat of the revolt. Not least among these were soldiers from the recently conquered Punjab, who felt no affection for the Bengal sepoys who had defeated them. In addition, neither the Bombay Army nor the Madras Army rebelled, so insuring that southern

India remained quiet. Among the most visibly ‘loyal’ were those, like the Bengali intelligentsia, who had had Western education, together with Bengal’s zamindars, tied to the Raj by the Permanent Settlement that secured their prosperity. India’s ruling princes too, in contrast to those among them who had lost their thrones, almost invariably calculated that their interests were best served by supporting their British rulers. Even among the rebellious Oudh landlords, many hedged their bets by sending emissaries to the British camp, and so in the end survived with their lands intact.

The revolt in the three northern cities of Delhi, Lucknow, and Cawnpore (Kanpur), and the Maratha-led uprising in central India, drew the greatest attention on the part of the British. Troops were massed in Bengal to move up the Ganges, with Benares and Allahabad retaken within little more than a month after the initial outbreak. On the march British troops, and even civilians, unleashed indiscriminate terror, ravaging the countryside and killing randomly. This racial savagery continued throughout the fighting, despite the governor-general Lord Canning’s effort – earning him the sobriquet ‘Clemency Canning’ – to curb such behaviour in the so-called Clemency Proclamation of July 1857. In the most extreme example of Indian violence, the garrison at Cawnpore surrendered to Nana Sahib who, despite his promise of safe passage; rained fire on them as they attempted to board boats; British women and children were also massacred, some 400 in all. Delhi was retaken in September thanks to reinforcements from Punjab. Bahadur Shah was exiled to Burma, the royal sons murdered. In Lucknow Sir Henry Lawrence, the new chief commissioner, secured both Europeans and Indians in the well-fortified Residency before succumbing himself in July. The garrison and their dependents were not liberated until November, and the province itself was not fully recovered until well into 1858. The Maratha leaders, the Rani of Jhansi, who was to fall in battle, Nana Sahib, and Tantia Topi, prolonged the fighting in central India, although with the fall of Gwalior in June 1858 the fighting was effectively over.

On 2 August 1858 the British Parliament passed the Government of India Act, transferring all the authority of the East India Company to the British Crown. The Company had come to seem a mere shell, its trade monopoly long since gone, even the patronage power of

appointment (of which John Beames was one of the final examples) revoked in favour of competitive examination in 1853. Shared Company and parliamentary control at home, and nominal subservience to the Mughal in India, appeared as outdated anomalies profoundly implicated in the revolt's heavy cost in British lives and revenue.

The pattern of twenty-year charter reviews now gave way to regular parliamentary scrutiny of Indian affairs. A cabinet member, the Secretary of State for India, advised by a Council of India, was given authority for the government of India. In India supreme authority was vested in the Viceroy, the title assumed by Governor General Canning when Queen Victoria proclaimed these changes to the 'Princes, Chiefs, and People of India' in November 1858. The viceroy was to be advised by an executive council (originally set up with exclusively British membership in 1853), now expanded for legislative purposes by up to twelve new members, of whom half were to be 'non-official', that is, not employed by the colonial government. That small step began the progress of political arithmetic common throughout the Empire as over time the number and level of councils; the number of members of each body; the proportion of official and non-official, appointed and elected, members; the opportunity to advise on subjects presented or initiate discussion or even have legislative power in some or another sphere, all lurched forward in fits and starts. This constitutional reform was a response to the pleas of Indians like Sayyid Ahmad for consultation, bringing in this case the voice of carefully selected Indian aristocrats to the viceroy's ear. The change to Crown rule also ushered in an elaboration of bureaucratic and technical structures, a change taking place in Britain as well in this period, from police and sanitation to forestry and finance. This last was a subject of immediate attention given the financial costs of the revolt, all of which were charged to India.

Victoria's proclamation further responded to presumed causes of the revolt. In a reversal of Dalhousie's policy, the proclamation guaranteed the princes their titles. No longer were limits put on adoptions: princely 'rights, dignity and honour', as well as control over their territory, would be respected. This meant that about one-third of the people of India were, until the end of the Raj, to remain under the 'indirect rule' of some 500 princes. The government would

endeavour, moreover, to promote ‘the peaceful industry of India, to promote works of public utility and improvement’ in the expectation of the ‘social advancement that can only be secured by eternal peace and good government’. And the proclamation explicitly repudiated any ‘desire to impose our convictions on any of our subjects’ and enjoined ‘all those who may be in authority under us’ to abstain from interference with Indian religious belief or worship. ‘Due regard’ would be paid to ‘the ancient rights, usages, and customs of India’.

The theory of rule enunciated in this proclamation contained an implicit contradiction. On the one hand, there was the language of a feudal order that stressed the role of hereditary leaders. By so doing the British sought, for the most part successfully, to make of India’s princes and large landlords a conservative bulwark for the Raj. On the other hand, the proclamation also expressed a conception of politics associated with British parliamentarism and the liberal political theory of such men as Macaulay. Its inauguration inevitably would undermine the hereditary rulers. In 1859, Lord Canning undertook a series of tours, holding courts, called ‘darbars’ in superficial emulation of Mughal practice, to recognize not only loyal princes but also landlords, among them the large landlords of Oudh, now invested with honours and titles as aristocratic bulwarks of British rule. In Bernard Cohn’s words, already incipient was ‘a social order . . . established with the British Crown seen as the centre of authority, and capable of ordering into a single hierarchy all its subjects’. No reversal of Dalhousie’s policy, Canning’s incorporation of the princes marked the completion of his predecessor’s search for a unified sovereignty over India.

A corollary of this new order was a centrally important assumption about the very nature of India: that it was a land made up of a congeries of peoples diverse in their culture, society, and religion, and that the foreign ruler alone peacefully contained that diversity. This assumption was most evident in the military policy that emerged after the revolt. At its heart was a pseudoscientific theory of ‘martial races’, by which particular categories of people were singled out for military service on presumed grounds of innate physical and moral characteristics which made them the best fighters. These groups comprised above all the loyal Punjabis – Sikhs, Jats,

Rajputs, and, in due course, Punjabi Muslims – along with Pathans and Nepali Gurkhas. By 1875, half of the native army was Punjabi, with far-reaching implications for the history of that region. Regiments were now, moreover, ethnically mixed in the expectation that cultural difference would prevent collusion. Only British officers were placed in control of artillery. The proportion of British personnel was substantially increased. At the time of the revolt, British soldiers comprised barely one-sixth of the Bengal Army; now the proportion of British to Indian was targeted to be one to two or three.

The uprising intensified British racism. Suspect sepoys were blown from cannons. Delhi was sacked and monuments wantonly destroyed or appropriated to military use. Coupled with the trial for treason and exile of the emperor, the previous regime and its rulers were effectively ‘desacralized’. Muslims were initially prime targets of British distrust as ‘fanatics’ who would try to restore Muslim rule. Within two decades, however, Muslim aristocrats came to be seen, like the princes, as pillars of loyalty, a role not uncommon in authoritarian settings where ‘minority’ loyalties are cultivated. In this transition Sayyid Ahmad Khan played a central role. In Aligarh in 1875 he established the Anglo-Muhammadan College, an English-style institution that cultivated gentlemanly skills and conservative politics intended to produce the kind of people appropriate to the loyal consultative regime he had advocated in 1858.

The British never conceived of the rebel leaders as honourable opponents, but rather lumped them all together as ‘disloyal’, and treated them accordingly. Nana Sahib’s murder of British women in particular stirred a fierce hatred. This act left an enduring legacy in Victorian paintings and mass market novels filled with lurid accounts of rape and mutilation that threatened the ‘purity’ of British womanhood. John Beames, travelling to Punjab two years after the revolt, wrote of his passage through Cawnpore:

The fading daylight lasted long enough to enable me to take a hurried glance at the ghastly place; a desolate, sandy waste it then was. The dreadful well [where the bodies of women and children were thrown] was marked by a few boards, the walls of the roofless houses were riddled with shot and tottering; ruins, flies, evil odours and general misery and distress were all one could see . . . [a] horrible place.



Plate 4.2 Memorial well, Cawnpore, photograph 1903.

The well was soon commemorated by a marble memorial, shown in [plate 4.2](#), designed by the Italian sculptor Marochetti. This photograph, part of a set of stereoscopic views, was meant to remind the British at home of the sacrifices they had endured in India. Cawnpore was a major centre on what emerged in the late nineteenth century as a kind of ‘mutiny tour’ for British travellers, who travelled from the Lucknow residency, the one place in the Empire where the Union Jack after the revolt was never lowered; to Cawnpore; to the Delhi ridge. The ‘mutiny’ offered the British a cleansing sense of heroism and self-assertion, a confirmation of moral superiority and the right to rule. Henry Lawrence’s tomb in Lucknow, in accordance with his wish, identified him only as one ‘who tried to do his duty’.

**THE STRUCTURING OF THE RAJ: SECURITY,
SANITATION, ORDERING SOCIETY**

The fear and racism evident at the time of the revolt took visible shape in the decades following, as the British created separately demarcated spaces for themselves. In cities these areas were labelled 'civil lines', with associated 'cantonments' for the military. In mountainous regions they established 'hill stations' that served as summer refuges not only for individuals but for the colonial governments. The building of these areas went hand in hand with an increased number both of settled families, their presence made easier by improved communications of the day, and of British military personnel. These spaces communicated racial difference as well as the threatening disorder and 'putrid air' understood to characterize the old cities. They represented, moreover, as part of lived experience, an association of British culture with the 'modern' in contrast to the older sections of the city seen as 'medieval' or 'traditional' – always the necessary foil to modernity. The 'colonial city' was predicated on such duality.

This concern with the disorder of old urban centres confronted Europeans at home at the same time, where it was stimulated by rapid urban growth, breakdown in sanitation, and alarming epidemics. Disease was attributed to the 'miasmatic' theory of atmospheric impurities produced by decomposing matter and damp in overcrowded settlements. The theory was specious; the remedies – drainage, removal of refuse, a safe water supply, and, ideally, less crowding – were sound. The 1842 Chadwick Report had spoken of the lower classes – in a language that would have served equally well for the old cities of India – as a population 'short-lived, improvident, reckless, and intemperate, and with habitual avidity for sensual gratification'. In India, however, such judgments were mapped on to 'race'; and whatever official action was taken privileged European interests. The earliest sanitary concerns focused on the military, whose poor health was clear from the fact that in 1857 the death rate among British soldiers, as in the Crimea a few years before, was higher from disease than from battle.

A useful illustrative example of the way health and safety drove urban design can be found in the city of Allahabad, capital of the

North-Western Provinces (known as the United Provinces (UP) after its unification with Oudh in 1902). Allahabad was always one of the great pilgrimage centres of the subcontinent, celebrated for its location at the confluence of the Ganges and Jamuna rivers, as well as the mythical Saraswati. The city's population varied during the course of the year, swelling in the winter month of Magh when pilgrims converged, and even more so every twelfth year, when holy men and throngs of believers flooded into the city from all over the country. The British feared itinerancy in all forms so that Allahabad seemed a particularly dangerous site for health and safety. The Mughals, recognizing the strategic location of the city, had had a presence there, and Akbar's fort, overlooking the river, remained. The old city had two or three main streets, but from these a labyrinth – as the British saw it – of narrow streets led off to distinct neighbourhoods, some still with gates fastened at night. The houses, mixed together with shops and warehouses, looked inwards and were densely built. There were several markets for grain and fodder. With the establishment of sanitary commissions and municipal councils, efforts were made to improve sanitation in the old city, but resources were disproportionately directed towards its European areas.

The rail line, in Allahabad as elsewhere, was seen as the main strategic defence for the European population, and so, as it cut through the city, formed a barrier between the civil lines to the north, laid out in 1858 immediately after the revolt, and the old city. In the civil lines area, existing villages were removed and replaced with paved streets and covered gutters, set out on a grid pattern and lined with newly planted avenues of trees. Population density was very low, with European residents living in 'bungalows', a distinctive colonial housing style meant to provide ventilation and protection from heat, in plots that could be as large as 10 acres (plate 4.3). The civil lines contained the buildings around which European colonial society revolved: government offices, the club, polo field, church, and shops. Social life – visiting, balls, certain sporting events, social drinking – were modelled on upper-class behaviour and were exclusively European.

The military cantonment, again laid out on a regular grid, was directly north of the old city and, to further reassure the European civilian population, immediately adjacent to their residential



Bungalow next to the Church, Allahabad 1866

Plate 4.3 Bungalow, Civil Lines, Allahabad, photograph 1866. Note the encircling verandah, where visitors were entertained and business transacted with Indians, and the bungalow's placement in the centre of a large secluded compound with curving entry drive.

area. Two settlements buffered the margin between European and 'native'. One was a settlement of Eurasians or 'Anglo-Indians', near the railway station. Anglo-Indians, a living denial of racial difference, were often seen as an embarrassment to the British, but a niche for them was found in railway employment in the expectation that their loyalty could be relied upon. The second colony was that of Bengalis, whose numbers grew in 'up-country' cities and towns as their literacy gave them an advantage in government employment. It was, of course, impossible to tie a tight cordon around European society, and servants, traders, and others both entered and lived in the areas intended for Europeans, and many sites – from government offices to educational institutions and asylums, commercial places, and the frequent Masonic temple – were places of defined and limited interaction between races.

Beames was posted in 1869 to a small coastal town in Orissa. His description of 'our small society' suggests the make-up of the

European population after the revolt. He was the magistrate and collector (the chief official of the district). In addition, the English population included ‘a Joint Magistrate, a doctor, a Superintendent of police, an Engineer, a Harbour-master, and an Inspector of Telegraphs . . . also two police Assistants and a Deputy Magistrate’. Other Europeans were missionaries, in this case not English but American Free Will Baptists and a Belgian Jesuit. The latter lived, as Beames saw it, like a native fakir, and he raised money to build – to the admiration of officers of the Public Works Department – a church, school and dormitories, and a nunnery. That Beames mentions officials employed in medicine, police, engineering, telegraphs, and public works points to the expanded technical bureaucracies that emerged in the late nineteenth century. Although he draws vivid vignettes of the colourful Europeans he encountered in his career, Indians appear but rarely.

Beyond their separate urban residential areas, the British sought further distance from what they saw as a disease-ridden land by escape to the Himalayas in the north and Nilgiri Hills in the south, a pattern begun even before the revolt for convalescent troops. In 1865, John Lawrence as viceroy made Simla, some 50 miles into the hills and 900 miles from Calcutta, the regular summer capital of British India. Missionaries and princes in turn created ‘hill stations’ of their own in such places as Mussoorie and Kodaikanal, Murree and Mount Abu. Women and children often came to the hills for several months while men perforce stayed behind, visiting whenever they could. Fear of specific disease was in the end less important than a range of anxieties about the dangers of life in India, among them fear of degeneration brought on by too long residence in a debilitating land. The hills were meant to reproduce England. Lord Lytton, arriving as viceroy in a rainy Ootacamund in the 1870s, rhapsodized over ‘such beautiful *English* rain, such delicious *English* mud’. In the hills, in place of the civil station of the plains, were English cottages and country houses, gardens of English flowers, English fruits and vegetables, a bandstand, and a mall, its buildings often half-timbered to reproduce an English country town. There were many hill schools, but European children, whenever funds permitted, were sent home for schooling. The colonial British themselves returned ‘home’ to retire.

As the British distanced themselves from Indian society, they sought, ever most insistently after the upheaval of 1857, to order and control it. Among the institutions forged in these post-revolt decades were the Survey of India, founded in 1878, and the first Census of India, compiled in 1872 and carried out on an India-wide decennial basis from 1881. After the revolt, new regulations required that newspapers and journals be registered (see the number in the upper left-hand corner of [plate 4.5](#)), and copies of books and pamphlets had to be transmitted to the government. The systematized Hindu and Muslim civil law codes, rigidifying and simplifying practice, were finally enacted into law in the 1860s. People who moved had always been suspect; now pastoral and other itinerants were associated with ‘criminality’, and defined as ‘criminal tribes’. Late nineteenth-century British ideology elaborated an array of pseudo-scientific ‘racial’ differences, not only those of the criminal tribes, but also the notion of ‘feminine’ races (above all the feeble and spineless but clever Bengalis), as well as the ‘martial’ races discussed above. India was in sum a ‘living museum’ where ancient customs, habits, and practices endured up to the present.

The most important identity for Victorian anthropologists of India was ‘caste’, taken as a concrete, measurable ‘thing’ that could be fitted into a hierarchy able to be ascertained and quantified in reports and surveys. The increasing systematization of caste was closely connected with the use of photography, whose ‘exact’ images complemented the search for scientific precision. ‘Characteristic specimens’ could exemplify precise measures of physiognomy, dress, and manners. The first major compilation of such photographs was *The Peoples of India*, published by the Government of India in 1868 in eight volumes. The picture of the Banjaras, for example, nomadic herdsmen and traders, shown in [plate 4.4](#), was accompanied by a description of them as having ‘a reputation for perfect honesty’, but they were later relegated to the status of ‘criminal tribe’, a reminder of the fantasy that passed for exactitude. The caste ‘system’ is thus one of the countless parameters of life in India that is a product of modern change, as are other aspects of social life, not least the powerful position of princes, magnates, and gentry, bolstered by administrative action then, and now too often identified as ‘traditional’.



Plate 4.4 'Brinjara and Wife', from J. Forbes Watson and J.W. Kaye, *The Peoples of India*, 1868.

Such measuring and categorizing of peoples, places, and cultures in order to make the country's inhabitants 'legible' to its rulers was a worldwide phenomenon, a product of late nineteenth-century modernism, not a function solely of colonialism. Nevertheless, in a colonial setting like that of India limitations on an administrative ordering of society, above all from an independent 'public' and from representative institutions of government, were exceptionally weak. The quest for security after 1857 only strengthened this authoritarian imperative.

'NATURAL LEADERS' AND THE LANGUAGES OF MODERNITY

Keshab Chandra Sen (1839–84) was the third generation of an elite Bengali family associated with the commercial and cultural milieu intertwined with colonial rule. His grandfather had been a friend of Ram Mohan Roy. Sen himself had studied at Hindu College, and he spent his short life in exuberant (and in the end divisive) proselytizing for the Brahmo Samaj. A gifted orator with fluent English, he travelled throughout India, nurturing branches of the Samaj in areas as far as Bombay, above all in places where Bengalis in government service and trade had settled. In 1877, shortly after Victoria had assumed the title of Empress of India, he gave a speech in Calcutta:

Loyalty shuns an impersonal abstraction . . . We are right then if our loyalty means not only respect for law and the Parliament, but personal attachment to Victoria, Queen of England and Empress of India [Applause] . . . Do you not recognize the finger of special providence in the progress of nations? Assuredly the record of British rule in India is not a chapter of profane history, but of ecclesiastical history [Cheers] . . . All Europe seems to be turning her attention in these days toward Indian antiquities, to gather the priceless treasures which lie buried in the literature of Vedism and Buddhism. Thus while we learn modern science from England, England learns ancient wisdom from India.

It is perhaps not surprising that Keshab Chandra was one of many figures of like background who spoke, as he did here, in what was for the most part the language of British liberal politics. But the key words in the short paragraph quoted – 'loyalty', 'law and the Parliament', 'personal attachment', 'the progress of nations', 'modern

science', and 'ancient wisdom from India' – were, in the quarter-century from about 1860 to 1885, to be utilized by other, less Westernized, individuals as well. Such concepts structured discourse in a variety of settings, including the newly important municipalities, and in a variety of genres, not only in English but in the vernaculars, where newspapers and journals, public speaking, debates, petitions, tracts (like Saiyyid Ahmad Khan's on the revolt), and novels were shaping many Indian languages into their modern forms.

The event that stimulated Sen's lecture, the announcement of a new title for Victoria, took place twenty years after the great revolt. Making Victoria 'Empress' was intended to create a new bond between Britain and her chief imperial possession, one that Disraeli as Conservative prime minister imagined would be not only politically useful domestically, but welcome to what was presumed to be the Indian temperament. The title was announced at an 'Imperial Assemblage' orchestrated by the viceroy Lord Lytton (1876–80). It was held in the old Mughal capital of Delhi to underline the imperial motif, and was intended above all to recognize and solidify bonds with princes, rural magnates, and urban notables. They were now regarded, in a phrase that became common at this time, as the 'natural leaders' of their people, able to command the loyalty of those below them, and themselves loyal to the British. For the assemblage, Lytton fabricated a medieval vision of the viceroy as monarch surrounded by his loyal vassals, even presenting the princes with banners emblazoned with European-style coats of arms tailored to each recipient. Later assemblies (in 1903 and 1911) were called durbars in imitation of Mughal usage, and were organized in what was thought to be a more 'Indian' mode that emphasized Indian difference from Europe, not similarity. As Lytton proclaimed in 1877, such gatherings were meant to make visible an empire 'multitudinous in its traditions, as well as in its inhabitants, almost infinite in the variety of races which populate it, and of the creeds which have shaped their character'. At such events the language of 'feudalism' almost wholly pushed aside that of 'liberalism'.

In addition to such assemblies, the British sought to bind India's 'natural' leaders to themselves through the granting of awards, titles, and various privileges, as well as through inclusion in the municipal governments that became increasingly important in this period. In

addition to the princes, these favoured 'leaders' now included urban notables. Municipal boards were dominated by government administrators, with the district collector as president, but they also began now to include nominated 'non-official' members. There were two incentives to enhance the role of municipal boards. One was the increased financial pressure produced by the revolt, together with inflation resulting from shifts in the value of silver (the standard for the rupee), and enhanced military and other expenses. There was, for example, pressure both from the military and from manufacturing interests in England to spend more money on irrigation, roads, and railways. There were also demands for strictly municipal needs, among them sanitation ('conservancy'), new police charges (put in place by an act of 1861 that created a public police force), and a whole range of improvements common to Victorian cities and deemed appropriate for the empire as well – schools, parks, markets, fountains, clock towers and the like. These costs were now to be assumed locally, by such means as octrois, income and property taxes, and licence fees, with the police 'as the first charge on all such funds'.

Secondly, liberal imperialists wished to make the municipalities into schools for political education. There were many ironies in this position. First, of course, the 'liberal' view inevitably emphasized the 'backwardness' of Indians, who in this evolutionary understanding of human history needed education to overcome, above all, their lack of the unity England was taken to enjoy. Secondly, it juxtaposed the two inherently contradictory languages of politics implicit in the 1858 Proclamation. Municipal councillors were to be the voice of 'public opinion'. This concept had emerged in Europe and was understood to be the assembled opinion of those unfettered by obligations to hereditary elites or communities, in principle a voice autonomous of the state. This voice, in a second weighty phrase, would express 'the public good'. But the councillors were, of course, chosen precisely because they were loyal to the state, not autonomous. Moreover, they won recognition as the presumed representatives of specific communities. For such councillors, to enter the municipal board was to make a public statement of deference to the government. It meant in large measure supporting the goals of British civil servants, and it typically entailed furthering civic needs

through personal philanthropy. It also, typically, provided opportunities that would benefit particular groups. The municipal boards were the kernel that would later flower into legislative assemblies and other representative bodies embodying the same contradictions.

Indians were expected to develop universal loyalties and were criticized for parochialism, yet in colonial institutions they were given incentives to identify with particular religions and castes. When elections to the municipalities were introduced under Lord Ripon (viceroy 1880–4), the nominated seats, as Narayani Gupta has shown, were typically used to ‘balance’ the representation of communities, above all that of Hindus and Muslims. Despite the extremely diverse elements that comprised them, these two groups were now lumped together and conceptualized as ‘majority’ and ‘minority’. Articles in Delhi’s long-running *Lytton Gazette*, a biweekly Urdu journal of news and essays named in honour of the viceroy (see [plate 4.5](#)), often reflected the inherent tension in colonial ideology. In one issue the paper celebrated the 1877 assemblage, with its emphasis on ‘feudal’ loyalties, yet identified its purpose, using the language of modern civic consciousness, as *rifaah-i‘am*, ‘the public good’. It claimed as well to speak for ‘public opinion’, *‘awam ki khahish*.

Another way of contesting the British emphasis on the differences among Indians was to insist upon the participation of Indians throughout the country in a larger Hindu culture. Vasudha Dalmia’s study of the literary figure Harischandra, for instance, shows him constructing an incipient Hindu ‘public’. In an early editorial in English entitled ‘Public Opinion in India’ (1872), he wrote:

Unless there be a general desire to shake off the trammels of superstition, the regeneration of India cannot be aimed at. Let the religion of India be the religion that can govern the millions of her subjects without any let or hindrance. Let the dark shadows of sectarianism be vanished by the rays of Western civilization... and let the unity be the basis of that grand super-structure of national improvement which every civilised nation has in its possession.

Harischandra thus used modern concepts of progress and ‘national improvement’ to infuse an old term, that of ‘Hinduism’, with new roles and new meaning.

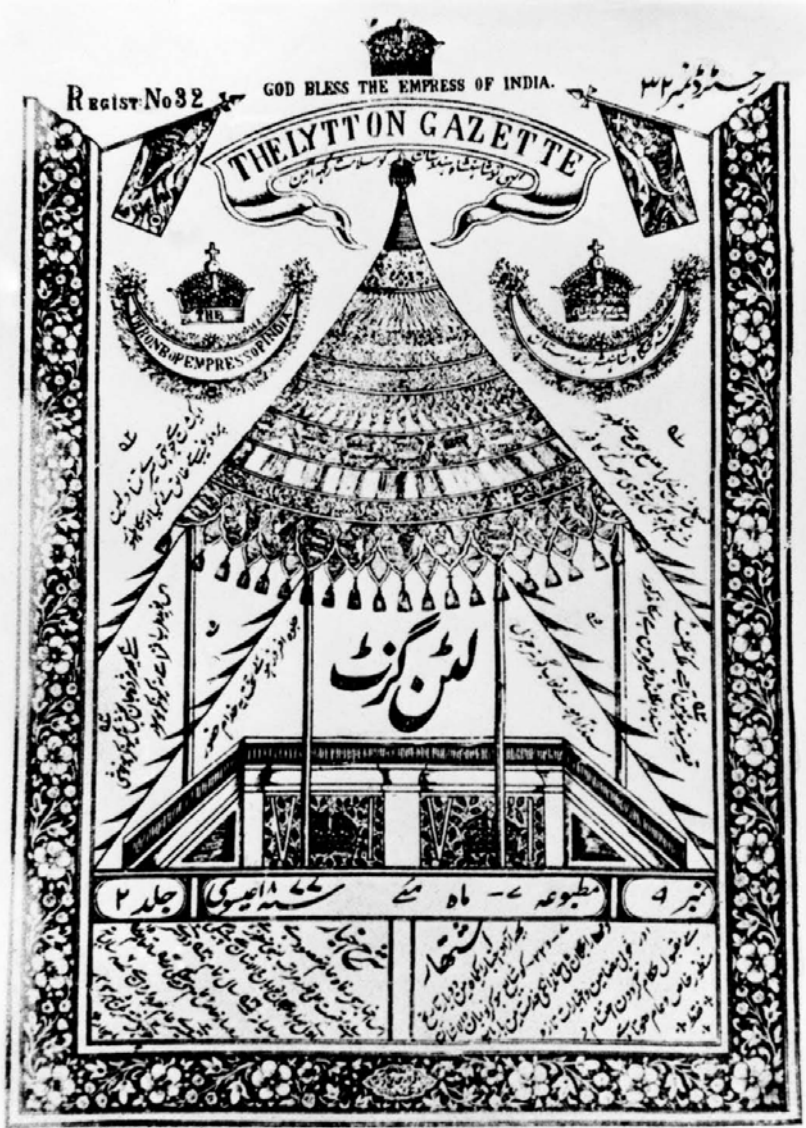


Plate 4.5 *The Lytton Gazette*, Urdu Newspaper.

THE ENGLISH-EDUCATED

The assemblage of 1877 was the first public recognition by the colonial government of the role of journalists, and the invitations to the event provided an occasion for journalists from across the country

to meet. These men, including many who published vernacular-language papers, were among what was emerging as a critical mass of English-educated elites throughout India. They were in part the product of Sir Charles Wood's Education Dispatch of 1854, further evidence of Dalhousie's modernizing impulse that had also set in place the first three Indian universities, one in each presidency capital, inaugurated in the fateful year of 1857. That act stimulated the foundation of private colleges and had also provided for grants-in-aid that encouraged the foundation of schools.

Three points must be made about this early cohort of the English-educated. First, they were representatives of the old professional elites in each region. This fact would have long-term consequences throughout the country as non-elites, for example non-Brahmans in the west and south, saw the disproportionate opportunities afforded to the tiny percentage of Brahmans who had secured a Western education. Secondly, English linked men from across India who shared no other spoken language. This was a necessary element in the forging of political ties and movements, as English, the cosmopolitan language, would prove to be in colonies throughout the world. A large proportion of the English-educated, moreover, would have experience of regions outside their own in the course of careers in government, law, or journalism, a further force for unity. Thirdly, the English-educated, better understanding the new idiom of liberal politics, would soon provide competition to the 'traditional' notables. Once electoral politics were introduced, they were the ones who most frequently stood for election.

Not surprisingly, they often used the values of liberal discourse to contest a range of British policies. In Lytton, for example, they found much to criticize, including the very holding of the assemblage in a time of widespread famine and limited administrative action to halt it. Lytton had, moreover, introduced legislation severely curtailing the vernacular press in the very year after the journalists had gathered. A year later he abolished the revenue tariff to secure unimpeded entry into the Indian market for Lancashire cotton textiles. His forward policy in Afghanistan was unpopular both in India and at home, and so contributed to Disraeli's downfall in the British elections of 1880. The outcome was the appointment of the Marquis of Ripon as viceroy by the liberal Gladstone.

The Western-educated class welcomed Ripon, who, in keeping with liberal sentiments, repealed the Vernacular Press Act of 1878 and, in his resolution of 1882, established a framework for local self-government with partially elected boards. Ripon's term, however, was blighted by the controversial Ilbert Bill, advanced by the law member of his cabinet to check the anomaly that while Indian members of the civil service could, as judges, try cases involving Europeans in presidency capitals, they could not do so in the countryside. The resulting outcry against the measure among Europeans in India showed the depth of British racial sentiment and offered unintended lessons in the power of 'public' opinion. The issue was resolved by allowing Europeans brought to trial to request a jury of whom half were Europeans; this new policy was now to prevail in the presidency capitals as well. Beames articulated the larger issues at stake when he wrote, describing his own opposition to the Ilbert Bill, 'It is intensely distasteful and humiliating to all Europeans . . . it will tend seriously to impair the prestige of British rule in India . . . it conceals the elements of a revolution which may ere long prove the ruin of the country.' The ceiling on Indian advancement in the governance of their own country had again been made clear. Despite the promises confirmed in the Queen's Proclamation of a non-discriminatory recruitment to the civil service, admission to the ICS became harder, not easier, in these years. Examinations were held only in London, not in India, and the maximum age for taking the examination was lowered in 1878 to nineteen. Under such restrictions no more than a tiny handful of Indians were even able to compete.

THE VERNACULARS

The second half of the nineteenth century was a significant period in defining and shaping the modern Indian languages like Bengali, Hindi, Urdu, Marathi, and Tamil. Missionaries, Orientalists, government officials, and, above all, the speakers of these languages transformed them through new uses. Influential vernacular publications were often the product of the new middle class where the 'feudal' and the 'liberal' coexisted, each changed by the other. Many of the quotations in this chapter are examples of the new genres

that shaped the vernaculars: the treatise (Sayyid Ahmad Khan), the public address (Keshab Chandra Sen), newspapers (*Lytton Gazette*, Harischandra), and, below, the novel (Nazir Ahmad). The vernacular novel in particular became a vehicle for exploring such issues as new class tensions, the choices of the educated classes, and the socialization of girls within the family. Nazir Ahmad's popular novels in Urdu, the official language through the Gangetic valley and Punjab, dismiss the old princely order in favour of the new culture of British India:

Daulatabad ('Prosperityville') was a rather small north Indian princely state. Although it could yield some 500 or 600 thousand rupees a year in revenue, an inexperienced youth sat on the throne. Sycophant counsellors and dissolute favourites seized the occasion... With a camaraderie like the Freemasons, they all knew about Daulatabad. So Kalim ('the Talker') kept hearing about it too, and longed for Daulatabad the way a pious mystic longs for heaven. So, doing double time, he made it to Daulatabad... On the way, he began composing a poem in praise of the prince, hoping it would win him favour... But a few days earlier the situation had turned upside down. News of the maladministration of the state had reached the [British] Resident, and he had... deprived the prince of all his power and entrusted the affairs of the state to a 'committee' composed of a few loyal old-timers, with Intizamud-Daula ('The Orderer of the Kingdom'), Mudabbiru'l-Mulk ('The Regulator of the Country') Nawwab Bedar Dil ('Vigilant Heart') K. B., the chief of 'Afiyatnagar ('Wellbeing Town'), as chairman.

This early novel, *The Repentance of Nasuh*, written in 1874, was one of the most popular books ever written in Urdu. Nazir Ahmad (1830–1912) came of a well-born Delhi family, and was educated in the Arabic and Persian tradition, but also in modern learning at Delhi College before the revolt. He worked for the Department of Public Instruction, translated the 1861 Indian penal code into Urdu, and rose to be a deputy collector in the North-Western Provinces. He seems to have taken as his model for this book Daniel Defoe's *The Family Instructor, Part I*. The book opens with Nasuh, stricken by an epidemic, dreaming that he is being called before the Last Judgment, a court which, not surprising given his background, looks like the British cutchery, but, the author notes in contrast, remarkable for the absence of personal interventions and pleading. When Nasuh is spared from illness, he sets out to reform his life and the life of his family. The novel communicates that only in the context of British

India is true religion – i.e. modern, reformed religion – possible. Nasuh's sons Alim and Salim find employment in British government service and in the newly 'scientific' field of indigenous medicine; Kalim, the third son, however, is a metaphor for the old life of aristocratic court culture, the world of poetry and pigeons. In the quote above, Kalim leaves British India for what will be an untimely end in a princely state. Only the British resident and the wise 'natural leader', an aristocrat recognized by the British title 'Khan Bahadur', offer any hope of honest government and right values. A second of Nazir Ahmad's successful novels, which takes up the issue of the reformed woman, is discussed in [chapter 5](#) below.

When Wajid 'Ali Shah, the last nawab of Oudh, left for exile he is said to have sung a poem in which he took on the persona of the bride leaving her natal house for the home of her husband – 'Oh father, my home is becoming foreign to me.' The poem appropriated a genre of Indic folk poetry, the bride's lament, to the sophisticated structures of Urdu verse. To the cognoscenti of Urdu, it was not only an empirical song of exile, but also the song of the soul ever seeking the Ultimate. Nazir Ahmad has Nasuh burn Kalim's library of poetry, for such verse was as 'decadent' to him as it was to British critics of the nawab. The new vernacular texts, then, were not untouched receptacles of 'traditions', but were critical in creating and communicating the new. In novels like Nazir Ahmad's and in the Bengali writings of Bankim Chandra and Rabindranath Tagore, discussed in the chapter that follows, the values of a new middle class were being reshaped, internalized, and rendered local, not 'foreign'. The vernaculars were, furthermore, critical in creating new publics, at once modern and, as part of that modernity, linked by language to identities that were both regional and religious. As the new vernacular literature exemplifies, Western models were transformed as they were incorporated into an Indian context.